Gokhale's 'Political Testament of 1914' stands out in this regard since it addressed the issue of 'provincial autonomy' with a certain degree of specificity. Subsequently, in October 1916, a Memorandum of post-war reforms was presented to the then Viceroy of India, Lord Chelmsford, by 19 non-elected members of the Imperial Legislative Council, which included Mahamana Madan Mohan Malaviya and Mohammed Ali Jinnah. The Memorandum outlined a 13-point scheme for self-government in Bharat. By December 1916, a scheme for self-government devised and formally approved by members of both the Indian National Congress and the Muslim League, known as the Congress–League Scheme, was passed at their respective annual sessions.[1]

The consequence of the growing chorus for self-government and the recognition of Bharat's contribution to the British war effort, both in terms of human resources and capital, was a declaration on 20 August 1917[2] in the House of Commons by the then Secretary of State for India Edwin Samuel Montagu, which read as follows:

> The policy of His Majesty's Government, which the government of India are in complete accord is that of increasing association of Indians in every branch of administration, and the Gradual development of self-governing Institutions with a view to the progressive realization of *responsible governments in India as an Integral part of the British Empire.* They have decided that substantial steps in this direction should be taken as soon as possible.
>
> *I would add that progress in this policy can only be achieved by successive stages. The British Government and the Government of India, on whom the responsibility lies for the welfare and advancement of the Indian peoples, must be the judges of the time and measure of each advance* [emphases added].

Indian nationalists saw this Declaration as an attempt by the British to defer 'self-government' by replacing it with 'responsible government', which was obviously not acceptable. Therefore, when Montagu arrived in India in November 1917 to ostensibly hold parleys with various groups, the Congress–League Scheme on self-government was pitched to him by various organisations. These and other efforts by a variety of stakeholders, primarily the Congress and the League, ultimately culminated in the